

Cold deserts

The largest cold deserts are in Central Asia, usually in high, flat areas. They are very dry, like all deserts, but are also very cold for most of the time. During the long winters, temperatures often drop as low as -40°C (-40°F).



Gobi Desert, Central Asia



Ross Island, Antarctica

Polar deserts

These are extremely dry and cold. Temperatures rarely rise above 10°C (50°F), even in summer. Some are covered in ice and snow all year, while others are covered in gravel and large rocks. Most of Antarctica is polar desert.

Desert landforms

Over thousands of years, many different natural features, or landforms, have developed in deserts. These include hills; mountains; narrow, steep-sided valleys called canyons; large, flat areas called plains; sand dunes; strange rock formations; and oases.



Sand dunes

These hills are formed by the wind blowing across the desert sand, so that it piles up.



Oases

Rare underground water can create pools of water. Plants then spring up around them.



Mesas and buttes

Sand and grit, carried by the wind, wear away rock to create these steep, flat-topped hills.